ALCOHOL

Know the risks. Recognise dependence. Find support.

ALCOHOL IS A DRUG
Alcohol affects the brain, mood and coordination. Drinking can lead to dependence. Problems with alcohol can affect anyone, whatever their background.

How does alcohol affect you?

Alcohol slows reactions and affects judgement. Drinking a lot at once can cause accidents, blackouts, vomiting, alcohol poisoning and dangerous decisions.

Longer-term health risks

Regular drinking increases the risk of liver disease, high blood pressure, stroke, heart problems and several cancers. It can also worsen sleep, anxiety and depression.

Signs of dependence

You may need more alcohol to feel the same effect, drink to cope with stress, struggle to cut down, or feel shaky, sweaty or sick when alcohol wears off.

Families are affected too

Problem drinking can affect family relationships, finances and feelings of safety. Partners, children and other carers may feel worried, alone or exhausted. **They deserve support too.**

IMPORTANT: DO NOT STOP SUDDENLY IF DEPENDENT
If you experience shaking, sweating or feeling unwell when alcohol wears off, speak to a GP or alcohol service before stopping. Sudden withdrawal can cause seizures or dangerous confusion.

THE KEY MESSAGE
Alcohol dependence is a health issue, not a moral failing. Help and recovery are possible.

RECOGNISE THE SIGNS. GET HELP EARLY.

Practical information for individuals, parents and families.

When to get urgent help

Call **999** if someone is unconscious, has slow or irregular breathing, has a seizure, or becomes severely confused during withdrawal. Stay with them and tell emergency services what happened.

What you can do

Speak to a GP or alcohol service if you are worried about drinking. If you may be dependent, get medical advice before cutting down or stopping. Families: talk privately, listen without blame and get support for yourselves.

UK law | England and Wales

Alcohol is legal for adults, but its sale and use are regulated.

POSSESSION: Adults can generally possess alcohol legally; ordinary possession is not a controlled-drug offence.

SELLING OR SUPPLYING: Selling alcohol generally requires the correct licence or authorisation. Selling alcohol to under-18s is illegal.

DRINK-DRIVING: Driving over the legal alcohol limit or while unfit: **at least a 1-year driving ban**, up to 6 months in prison and an unlimited fine.

Under-18s cannot buy alcohol. Adults generally cannot buy it for them. A limited exception allows 16- and 17-year-olds accompanied by an adult to drink beer, wine or cider with a meal in licensed premises.

Families, stigma and isolation

In some South Asian families, shame or fear of judgement can keep drinking hidden and delay treatment. A caring conversation and confidential help are better than blame or humiliation.

Free local support in Rochdale

TURNING POINT / ROAR | Adult drug and alcohol recovery support
0300 555 0234
EARLY BREAK | Young people and families
0161 723 3880
THE SALIK PROJECT UK | Education and help finding support
contact@salikprojectuk.org

You matter too. Seeking help is a sign of strength, not shame.

Sources: NHS alcohol-use disorder guidance; GOV.UK drink-driving penalties; GOV.UK alcohol and young people. Reviewed November 2026.